Annual Plan

A template for co-ordinating key events, commitments, and interactions across a company

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Benefits of an Annual Plan

- I was leading a division for the first time, and had to plan the work for my division while taking into account planned interactions with most other functions in the company as well. I had already witnessed previously the surprise and panic when budgeting and performance appraisals were due, in spite of the fact that these took place at the same time ever year. I created this annual plan as a way of mapping major events so that I could remain synchronised, but realised that there was no macro-planning at the company level for me to fix on.
- The annual plan needs to exist at the company level, enabling the company to synchronise around major events, interactions, and mutual obligations. The benefits are immediate and significant for managers who can prepare, be punctual, and also plan their own work in the confidence that it won't be sabotaged by external important and urgent obligations. The aim is to synchronise the company so that each division or part can plan and perform their work without being surprised by regular, fixed events.

Excel template

Download at https://Punkfrog.se

No.	Events	Q1																	
		January					February				March				April				
		W1	W2	W3	W4	W5	W6	W7	W8	W9	W10	W11	W12	W13	W14	W15	W16	W17	W18
		29 Dec	5 Jan	12 Jan	19 Jan	26 Jan	2 Feb	9 Feb	16 Feb	23 Feb	2 Mar	9 Mar	16 Mar	23 Mar	30 Mar	6 Apr	13 Apr	20 Apr	27 Apr
101	•																		
102	•																		
103	•																		
104	•																		
105	•																		
106	•																		
100	Shareholders / Board of Directors																		
201	•																		
202	•																		
203	•																		
204	•																		
200	Marketing & Sales																		
300	Human Resources																		
400	Finance																		
500	Legal / Compliance																		
600	Operations / Delivery																		

Configure the Template

Begin the new financial/calendar year

- Set the date in Cell H4 to the Monday of the week which contains the first day of your financial year.
  - N.B. entering the date will follow the format mm/dd/yy, regardless of how it is displayed in the cell.
  - e.g. If financial year starts 1st Jan, in 2026 that day falls on Thursday of week 1, and week 1 2026 has its Monday on 29th Dec.
- Some years have 53 weeks. Insert week columns where necessary to ensure that you incluse weeks for 1st January and 31st December.
  - Tip: insert columns inside the table to maintain same data and formatting.
- The number of weeks in a month varies from year to year. I count how many weekdays are in each month, and move it to the month where most days fall.
  - N.B. When you move weeks into other months, you will also need to modify the border of the Month, and Quarter to ma
- There are six sections in this template, representing six major parts of a company. Rename and add sections to represent all the functions in your company.
  - N.B. I include a section for shareholders and members of the board, which is beyond the operations of the company, but it is good for everyone including the CEO to see the overall alignment between functions.

Decide Which Events to Plan

The most difficult part is deciding which events are important enough to plan.
The fewer the better.
We want to show the necessary and sufficient events, and not drown in information.

Column	Description	Usage
C - Events	The list of major events, interactions, and obligations across the company, divided into sections representing each function, division, or department.	Do not go into too much detail; use the following ciriteria as a guide:- • Do other divisions/departments need to know about this event? That is, do they contribute, and need to know when this occurs? • Do I need to announce that I have a fixed commitment at this date, which blocks our availability for other considerations? • Is this event/work fixed and regular? That is, everyone benefits by knowing this is advance.
D - Per	The frequenecy of the event.	How often is it today? Is it too often, or need to be more often? As this is supposed to be m,ajor cross-company co-ordination, question whether weekly or shorter should be in the plan.
E - Timing	The constraints that need to be considered when scheduling this event.	e.g. Company bylaws might specify that the invitation for a board meeting and all supporting documentation must be made 30 days prior to the meeting. Nevertheless, it is common to get the information the night before, so no-one can be prepared for the meeting. If the week of the board meeting is fixed, this will never be an issue.
F - Responsible	The role in the company which is responsible for this event taking place, and approving the schedule.	
G - Receiver(s)	Shows who is directly affected by this event.	

Once this section is completed and all events have been planned for the year, columns D-G can be collapsed to reduce clutter.

Planning the Year

- The annual planning happens in the calendar section (columns H-BH) of the template.
- Explanations will use this example:-

No.	Events	Per	Timing	Responsible	Receiver(s)	Q1																
						January					February				March				April			
						W1	W2	W3	W4	W5	W6	W7	W8	W9	W10	W11	W12	W13	W14	W15	W16	W17	W18
						29 Dec	5 Jan	12 Jan	19 Jan	26 Jan	2 Feb	9 Feb	16 Feb	23 Feb	2 Mar	9 Mar	16 Mar	23 Mar	30 Mar	6 Apr	13 Apr	20 Apr	27 Apr
101	• Call to AGM	Annum	4-6w prior	Board	Shareholders																		
102	• Annual General Meeting	Annum	< 6 m EOFY	Chairperson	Shareholders																		28
103	• Call to Board Meeting	Quarter	7d prior	Chairperson, MD	Board of Directors, MD																		
104	• Board Meeting	Quarter	Mar, Jun, Sep, Dec	Chairperson	Board of Directors, MD					28													
105	• Annual Budget	Annum		MD	Board of Directors																		
106	• Annual Business Plan	Annum		MD	Board of Directors																		
100	Shareholders / Board of Directors																						

- In row 4, the date will automatically turn from green to yellow once the week has passed. In this example, the columns for January and February can now be hidden to reduce clutter.
- Following the conventions of a Gantt chart, planning is denoted by blue cells.
- The plan can be that the event will take place within a period (e.g. 101), within a week (e.g. 103), or on a specific date (e.g. 104). The more specific a fixed event is, the better for the organisation to synchronise, and plan around it.

The Benefits

Illustrated using the board meeting in the example

It seems (and is) a very simple thing to do, and obvious once you know.

- If the event is set at the same time each year, it becomes routine. Everyone knows when it will occur, and will start preparing their input for the meeting.
- If (as is common) busy managers first realise there is an impending board meeting when they receive the invitation to attend (and present) one week prior to the meeting (which can be dictated by national labour law, or company bylaws) it is disruptive.
- Managers are not always called to present at board meetings, but they will most usually be expected to provide data and materials.
- If, however, managers know that the board meeting will always be held in the last week of January, they can either block time or avoid accepting new work the week before when they will need to prepare for the board meeting.

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Avoid Surprises with an Annual Plan

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